

LIES

And so Venith, in his grey cloak and shadowed form, hobbled first to Aster in that dark and horrid place and picked up a brush to paint for him.

He painted the great cities of men, with tall churches and high priests who looked down upon him and choked him. He painted forests of humble elves speaking with spirits who shunned him. He painted mountains of stout dwarves with no greed in their eyes—no need to dig ever downward into the deep. And when he was done, he showed his art to Aster and said, “Look upon the world to come—the world of Serna. This is the world of good, a perfect world where the wars are bloodless, where the righteous triumph, and where no one is afraid of the dark. Give me the power to help you...” with a sudden stroke, he slashed the canvas with a dark and sickening color “...and I can make the world fear again.”

Aster looked upon the ruined painting and could not drive it from his mind. He too knew he was fighting a war he was losing. Every day his enemies grew stronger—more bold, more daring—pressing ever closer to the light. And it made him furious. His rage burned red and white-hot, a searing, ancient pain. And so the great Aster made a gamble: a foolish one, like a drunken bet born of desperation after a long night of losses. He surrendered his dark power of lies to the one called Venith, and Venith smiled and promised him a great repayment for this gift.

And so Venith lied to Aster, and spoke next to Serna.

— Spell, *Venith's Grand Lie*